Apple Messages for Business

Conversation Design Standards and Best Practices

What Apple documents, what Apple has told us directly, and what we have seen in real reviews

Prepared by Messaging Advisory Version 2.1 | 31 August 2026

Document metadata

- document: Conversation Design Standards and Best Practices
- version: 2.1
- scope: design standards only. The process is in Document 1. The test cases are in Document 3. The recording rules are in Document 4.
- audience: conversation designers, product owners and build teams
- changes in 2.1: added the fail criteria index; added the live agent console rule at 2.3 [Feedback]; indexed the card image rule

How to read this

This document has two parts.

Section 2. Apple's standard. What Apple documents and what Apple has told us directly. A failure here sends the experience back. Every rule carries a source tag.

Section 3. What we have seen in reviews. Field observations from Messaging Advisory and patterns that recur in real review feedback. These carry no Apple authority. They are what separates an experience that passes from one that works.

On the numbering. Section 1 of the previous combined document was the process. It now lives in Document 1, the Experience Review Process Overview. Section numbering here is unchanged from v1.0 so that every cross reference already in circulation still resolves. This document therefore starts at Section 2. That is deliberate.

Source tags used in Section 2

Tag	Source
[CDS]	Apple, Conversation Design Standards v3.1, 21 July 2026
[MWYC]	Apple, Message with Your Customer v3.1, 21 July 2026
[Journey]	Apple, Plan Your Customer's Journey v3.1, 21 July 2026
[Ops]	Apple, Ops and Marketing Preparation v3.1, 21 July 2026
[ER]	Apple, Pass the Experience Review v3.1, 21 July 2026
[Checklist]	MSP Integration Checklist, Apple Feedback Update, 30 July 2026
[Feedback]	Direct Apple feedback on live integrations

A note on naming

Apple requires the full name **Apple Messages for Business** in customer facing and public materials, and explicitly prohibits the abbreviation "AMB" in public communications [Ops]. Where the short form appears in our internal working files it must not survive into anything a client publishes, and it should not appear in file names shared externally. The full naming table is at Section 2.12.

Replace [BRAND] and the bracketed examples with your own.

Apple's fail criteria, and where each is answered

Document 1 lists the criteria Apple passes and fails an experience on. This table maps every fail criterion to the rule in this document that prevents it. Three of them are marked [Feedback], meaning Apple has told us directly rather than stating them in the v3.1 written criteria.

Fail criterion	Answered at
Text only experiences that do not leverage platform features	2.18, 2.5, and the audit habit at 3.2
Dead ends	2.4
Missing disclosures	2.4 automated disclosure, 2.9 opt out, 2.11 privacy policy and terms of use
Incorrect product naming	2.12
Bare URLs	2.7, and the "tap to load" variant at 3.7
Broken flows	2.2 conversation shape, 2.4 recovery and escalation
Lack of images [Feedback]	2.6 the card image rule, 2.6 row thumbnails, 2.7 every Rich Link carries an image
Slow response times	2.4 the 5 second rule, 2.3 wait time expectations, 3.9 time to first reply

Fail criterion	Answered at
Poor human agent console interactions [Feedback]	2.3, the live agent console
Missing or broken fallbacks [Feedback]	Not a design rule in this document. Apple wants to see that a fallback exists, and it is on the brand to demonstrate it: Document 4, Video 3, and the corresponding test cases in Document 3. 2.5 Keep the fallback decision tree written down as well
Policy violations	2.9 consent, 2.10 prohibited phrasing, 2.11 privacy and personal information

Typical Apple feedback, and where each item is answered

These are the themes that come back most often in real Apple feedback. Each one is a rule somewhere in this document. This table is the index into them, so a team responding to a feedback report can go straight to the relevant rule. It is not a separate list of guidance and it introduces nothing new.

Feedback theme	Answered at
Automated agent disclosure missing or buried	2.4
Lack of rich elements in the conversation, becoming pure text	2.5, 2.18, 3.2
No triage menu when intent is unclear	2.4
Notifications enabled without an active opt in, or no opt out stated	2.9, 3.3
Flow ends without offering further help	2.3
Bot goes silent or ignores an input it cannot classify	2.4
A formal Form used for one or two fields	3.4
Dead ends anywhere in the flow	2.4, and a named Apple failure
Prompts that do not trigger QuickType	2.8
Customer asked to repeat information already given	2.3
Bare URLs, or "tap to load" text links	2.7, 3.7
Interactive items with no thumbnail or icon	2.6
The rich card itself carrying no image, only the rows	2.6, and the field note at 3.2
A live agent exchange that feels slow or awkward on either side	2.3
Form missing a splash screen, title, intro or review screen	2.6, 3.4
Form context buried in the subtitle instead of a preceding bubble	2.6, 3.4
Long text inside a feature bubble, cropped before the customer decides	2.6, 3.4
List Picker used where a Quick Reply would do	2.6

Feedback theme	Answered at
Out of hours handling that offers no way to leave a message	2.3
Escalation that pushes the customer out of the channel	2.3, 3.5
Handoff to a person not announced, or no wait time given	2.3
Prohibited closing phrases	2.10
Satisfaction survey fired after every interaction	2.10
Messages sent entirely in lowercase	3.6
Quick Reply summary text repeating the whole previous message	2.6

Section 2. Apple's standard

Everything in this section is drawn from Apple documentation or direct Apple feedback. A failure sends the experience back. Each rule carries its source.

2.1 The six design principles [CDS]

Apple names six. Every design decision should be traceable to one of them.

Principle	What Apple says
Privacy First	Collect only what is necessary, when it is necessary. Protect customer data at every step of the conversation.
Tap Friendly	Minimise typing. Use Quick Replies, List Pickers and Time Pickers to let customers navigate with a single tap.
Fast by Default	Respond within seconds. Use automation to eliminate wait times and get customers to answers without delay.
Smart Automation	Use bots for triage, FAQs and routine tasks. Escalate to live agents seamlessly when human judgment is needed.
Built to Scale	Design flows that handle high volume efficiently without sacrificing experience quality for any individual customer.
Rich and Engaging	Leverage Rich Links, images and interactive features to create experiences that feel native, visual and effortless.

Our own working translation of these six into design decisions is at Section 3.1. It is ours, not Apple's.

2.2 The shape of a conversation [Checklist]

A well formed conversation has five moments, in order: a prompt greeting that identifies the automation, a guided opening that establishes what the customer wants, the task itself, resolution, and a close the customer controls. Skipping the guided opening produces a bot that waits to be told what to do. Skipping the resolution moment produces a conversation that ends without confirming anything was achieved.

2.3 Agent behaviour, live and automated [CDS]

Agent self introduction. All agents, live or automated, should self identify when responding to a customer's first message.

Close with an offer to help. After resolving an issue, always ask if there is anything else you can assist with. Going straight from resolution to close is a named failure [Checklist].

Live support availability. Outside business hours, let customers know when a live agent will respond, or provide alternative channels together with a way to send and receive the responses inside the channel, for example an email composer with send and receive threaded back.

Live agent handoff, wait time. If a response is not immediate, set expectations with an estimated wait time. Give a queue position where you have one. Never pretend a person is available, and never silently drop a request [Checklist].

Note: A person must always be available in stated business hours [Checklist]. This is the default. Where availability is limited, that has to be agreed with Apple's regional team case by case, and the alternatives below apply only within that agreement.

Live agent handoff, notification. Always notify the customer when transferring them, and have the live agent introduce themselves. Give the reason for the transfer, and the customer never repeats information [Checklist].

Offer the in conversation message first when no agent is available [Checklist]. When the team is offline or at capacity, the first and default option is to leave a message in the conversation, with a stated response window such as the next business day. The agent then acknowledges that message and replies to it in the same thread when they are back. Callback and email are alternatives offered afterwards, never the first thing on the menu. The customer chose this channel, so keep the answer inside it.

Email is optional where there is no round the clock cover [Checklist]. Provided the message can be composed in channel and ideally returns to the customer as a message rather than as a separate email thread.

Collect key details before live agent escalation. Gather essential information before routing a customer to a live agent, reducing repetitive questions and helping agents assist faster.

Do not repeat previously provided information. Agents have access to the full conversation history. Never ask a customer to repeat information already provided. Acknowledge it and move forward.

Respect asynchronous messaging. The channel is asynchronous. Never push customers to respond immediately, and never use phrases like "This conversation has been closed" or "Finish conversation". Reassure them they can follow up anytime instead.

Typing indicators. When an agent, live or automated, starts composing a message, a typing indicator should be displayed. Use a one second typing indicator before each message in a sequence. The 30 July checklist widened this: **every outbound payload** gets its own indicator, not only text, including attachments, Quick Reply, List Picker, Time Picker, Form, Rich Links, the Authentication card and Apple Pay [Checklist]. The indicator appears only while something is genuinely being composed. One that is always on is worse than none, because it stops meaning anything [Feedback].

The live agent console [Feedback]. When a customer asks to talk to a person, Apple expects that to be a good experience on both sides of the conversation, not only on the device. The customer should feel the brand is responsive. The agent should find it easy to read the thread and to send, including the rich elements the conversation needs. A console that makes an agent slow, or that makes rich content awkward to send, shows up on the customer's screen as long silences and plain text, and that is what gets reviewed. Treat the console as part of the experience under review, not as internal tooling behind it.

2.4 Automated agent requirements [CDS]

Disclose and welcome within 5 seconds. The bot must immediately disclose that it is automated and send an auto welcome within 5 seconds of the first message. Say it plainly: "This is an automated assistant" or "I am an automated agent." When a customer asks whether they are talking to a bot, answer truthfully and immediately. Reviewers test this with a direct question.

Say what the bot is for, not only that it is a bot [Feedback]. Disclosure on its own leaves the customer no wiser about what they can do. Follow it immediately with the assistant's name and its scope: "I am [BOT NAME], here to help you with [WHAT IT COVERS]". A bot that discloses it is automated and then jumps straight to "what can we help you with?" does not satisfy this.

Note: This is also very important for Business invitations. If user tap “Yes” you must welcome the user and explain what he signed for (eg: We will send you notifications about deliveries and important information about your account)

Respond to actionable keywords. Keywords contain enough information to act without asking for more input. Matching is case insensitive and tolerates surrounding whitespace [Checklist].

Keyword	Action
AGENT, SUPPORT	Escalate to a person, or to the approved alternative → Route to live agent immediately
HELP, SPEAK	Apple routes 'help' to a live agent, reinforced elsewhere in the doc: 'Support keywords like help or agent to reach a live agent at any time'.
MENU	Return the triage menu

Keyword	Action
STOP, UNSUBSCRIBE	Stop sending immediately, across the brand and not only this thread [Checklist]
Talk to an Agent	In the case of AI agents, you can consider other options to identify intent and triage
REPRESENTATIVE, QUIT	These are optional proposed by MA

Triage menu. If the customer's intent is not detected from the entry point or initial message, send a triage menu at the start of the interaction with a Quick Reply covering the top reasons customers contact you, up to five [CDS, Checklist]. Two constraints: do not force the menu when the customer has already written a clear intent, answer what they asked; and keep the options current from real demand data rather than from an internal org chart [Checklist].

Confirm the context you already have [Checklist]. If the entry point told you the intent, the store or the order, say so rather than asking again. "I can see you are asking about order [NUMBER]" is a better opening than a menu.

Keep triage shallow [Checklist]. Never more than two levels deep. A route to a person appears on every menu.

Never dead end [ER]. Dead ends are a named failure criterion. Every path must have a next step. Even where the automation cannot answer, it provides a fallback or a way to escalate.

Recover, never ignore [Checklist]. When the automation cannot classify a turn, it apologises, says plainly that it did not understand, and puts the options back in front of the customer. The reference wording is "Sorry, I didn't quite understand that. Please select an option below", followed by the options as a Quick Reply. Offer two or three options and make at least one a route to a person, connecting to an agent or requesting a call back. Handing back only the menu that already failed is a loop rather than a recovery. One clarification at most. If the next turn is still unclear, escalate. Looping clarifications are a named failure.

Note: Do not make yourself repetitive on providing the exact the same message every time the agent is unable to understand the intent

End the use case with a follow up offer. After resolving a use case, offer a Quick Reply so the customer can respond with a single tap instead of typing.

Language detection, confirm before switching. For multilingual brands, use device locale for the initial language, then confirm with a Quick Reply before switching if a different language is detected. The locale is read from the device, never asked for. A conversation that opens by asking the customer what language they would like has thrown away information it already had [Feedback].

Fallback: Keep recorded a decision tree for fallback as built, mapping each interactive type in scope to its supported alternative and the OS floor that triggers the swap. Reviewers may ask to see the tree itself, not only its behaviour on device.

2.5 The platform feature inventory [Journey]

Apple fails "text only experiences that do not leverage platform features" [ER]. This is the inventory you are expected to draw from. Use what the task genuinely needs, and be able to say why you did not use the rest.

Quick Reply. Single tap responses instead of typing, keeping the conversation moving and reducing drop off.

- 2 to 5 options per menu
- Design your menu with the most common options first
- Ideal for triage menus, yes and no confirmations, and simple choices

List Picker. Options in a structured, scrollable sheet, when each choice benefits from an image or icon, a title and a short description.

- Best for product catalogues, service selection and location picking
- Can be organised into sections or categories
- Supports single or multiple selection

Time Picker. Available time slots directly in the conversation.

- Shows available slots from your calendar system
- Automatically detects and surfaces the customer's calendar conflicts
- Customer can add the selected time to their calendar
- Ideal for appointments, deliveries and service bookings

Apple Pay. Payment completed with Face ID or Touch ID without leaving Messages.

- No card details entered manually, uses cards already saved in Wallet
- Payment is processed without leaving the conversation

Forms. Rich, multi page interactive flows delivered in the conversation.

- Text fields, dropdowns, checkboxes and date pickers
- Ideal for triage flows, satisfaction surveys, account creation and service sign ups
- Strong for hospitality: stay details, check in and check out dates in one flow
- Supports marking responses as private for sensitive data handling. This is the mechanism to use when a form must take something sensitive.

Authentication. Secure account access inside the conversation.

- OAuth 2.0 with password autofill
- Customers authenticate without leaving Messages
- Enables access to order history, account details and more

Rich Links. A preview image, title and source URL when a link is shared.

- Use for product pages, support articles and self serve resources

- Builds trust with a branded preview before the customer taps

Rich Links, video.

- Video plays inline without leaving Messages
- Ideal for product demonstrations and tutorials

App Extension. Your app experience is embedded in the conversation, without switching apps.

- Custom app interface inside the thread
- Ideal for complex selection flows such as menus, catalogs and orders
- Drives app adoption naturally from within Messages

Note: Do not forget Apple Maps or other type of rich elements like App Clips or Apple Music

2.6 Presenting interactive features [CDS]

Introductory text goes before the feature, never inside it. Send a text bubble immediately before the element, as an agent framing message. Use the first line as a clear title and a short subtitle such as "Tap here to start." Long text placed inside a List Picker may get cropped, and the customer decides without having read it. Eg: For Authentication and payments you can say "Please log into your account" before the Authentication card and then use the payment method if that is not Apple Pay [Checklist].

Business Invitations. A "Yes" is followed by an agent message explaining what the customer is signing up for.

Pair it with iconography. A relevant thumbnail across the **receivedMessage**, the **replyMessage** and **each individual item option**, so the items read as tappable. Icon style imagery is acceptable. Where you use symbols, use Apple's SF Symbols set rather than a third party icon font [Checklist].

Use Quick Reply for five options or fewer. If your List Picker would have five options or fewer, use a Quick Reply instead. It is faster and better suited to simple, text only selections, including binary confirmations. Do not force open text for a bounded question: "shall I add that to your order?" and "does this look right?" are Quick Replies. Typing is not forbidden and the customer may always type, so this is about what the conversation offers rather than what it permits [CDS, Feedback].

Put an image on the card, not only on the rows [Feedback, Checklist]. The rich card that carries an interactive element needs an image of its own. This is the most commonly missed rule in most reviews. The thumbnails on the individual rows are a separate rule and do not satisfy this one. A Form splash screen needs one too.

> **Apple Pay and the Authentication card are the exceptions** [Checklist]. Both render with Apple's own supplied iconography, so they do not take a brand card image and none should be added. The card image rule applies to List Picker, Time Picker, Form and Rich Links.

Keep the confirmation small [Feedback]. The reply that comes back after a tap, the summary_text, carries an image too (with exception of QuickReply), and it stays within the icon ceiling of about 150

pixels wide. A confirmation that renders as a large card competes with the element the customer has just answered, and the thread reads as two cards rather than as a question and an acknowledgement.

> **Eg: a Quick Reply summaryText.** The summaryText should be brief and represent the selected option concisely, for example "Option selected" or a short label. Avoid repeating full message content or using overly long text. Never use it as the introduction to the Quick Reply. The prompt belongs in the introductory text. Note: There is no such image for QuickReply

Give every item secondary text [Checklist]. A List Picker item showing a title alone forces the customer to guess. Populate the subtitle, and where the choice needs it the second and third subtitle lines, so each row can be told apart at a glance. Include a thumbnail on every row. Each field accepts 512 characters in the payload, but the rendered string is capped near 200. Keep the visible copy short and put any longer explanation in the introductory text.

Put the location on the Time Picker [Checklist]. When an appointment happens somewhere, populate the location of the event. The venue name and map pin render inside the picker, and the location travels with the calendar entry. Show the variants that apply: single select, multiple select and sections, alongside multiple time slots and icons. State the intended time zone in the payload rather than leaving it to be inferred.

Receive a shared location gracefully [Checklist]. A customer can share their location from the compose bar. Acknowledge it in the next message and reflect back what you understood, the resolved address or the place name, so the customer can correct it before anything is dispatched on it. Never let a shared location land in silence.

Build forms so the review page lands at the end [Checklist]. Where a Form runs to several pages, the Review button sits at the end of the final section to be filled, not in the middle of the flow.

2.7 Rich Links [CDS]

- **Always use a Rich Link for URLs.** Automatically detect all URLs, including videos, and convert them to Rich Link payloads with a live preview. **Never send a bare URL as plain text.** Bare URLs are a named failure criterion [ER]. This applies to what a human agent sends as much as to what the automation sends.
- **Send locations as Apple Maps links.** Whenever sharing a location, send it as an Apple Maps Rich Link (use the construct payload API) rather than a plain address, so customers get an inline map preview.
- **Rich Link image size.** When using a logo, including for Terms of Use or Privacy Policy links, use a square or rectangular image **under 150 pixels wide**. This results in a cleaner icon style display. Also elements rich cards should use small icons for better display on screen.
- **Asset specification** [Checklist]. The preview image is a PNG optimised at 240 by 240 pixels, up to 200 kB. This is a different rule from the 150 pixel ceiling: 240 by 240 is the asset specification, 150 pixels is the ceiling for icon style treatment.

- **Every Rich Link carries an image** [Checklist]. The image should reflect the page content rather than being a logo placeholder. If the destination has no Open Graph image, one is generated before sending.
- **Maps and Apple Music go through Construct Payload**, not through a Rich Link.

2.8 Data, identity and payment [CDS]

Use built in Authentication. Apple Messages for Business supports authentication endpoints that let brands verify a customer's identity **before sharing sensitive information such as order details, account data or balances**, ensuring it reaches only the right person. This is a positive obligation, not only a prohibition. If your flow returns an order status or a balance without authenticating, it does not meet this.

Use Apple Pay. Apple Pay is native to the platform and offers a seamless, secure payment experience. **Never request credit card details through the channel.**

Never request sensitive data as plain text [Checklist]. No full card numbers, no government ID numbers, no full social security numbers, no account passwords typed into the thread. Use Authentication for identity, Apple Pay for payment, and a Form Message with private responses for structured sensitive intake.

Gate the request [Checklist]. Before requesting personal information, ask a clarifying yes or no question such as "Is your inquiry related to your account with us?" Collect only on a yes.

Use QuickType prompts. Ask for customer information in a way that triggers QuickType suggestions on the device, so iOS suggests the answer and no typing is required.

Use these exact phrasings:

- What is your name?
- What is your last name?
- What is your email?
- What is your phone number?
- What is your address?
- What is your zip code?
- What is your location? / Where are you?

2.9 Consent and opt out [Checklist]

- **Opt in is an active choice.** A tap, not an inference, and never buried in a longer message. State how to opt out at the same moment, and record the brand, the channel, the purpose, the destination, the source, the timestamp and the disclosure version.
- **Consent is per brand, per channel, per purpose.** Never infer notification consent from a prior conversation, from an accepted invitation, or from consent given on another channel.
- **Nothing goes out unsolicited [Checklist].** Outbound is permitted only inside an ongoing conversation the customer started, or through an approved Business Invitation template. No SMS style marketing blasts, no cold sends, and nothing to a customer with no open conversation and no accepted invitation. Approved Invitation templates are the only sanctioned business initiated path; everything else on this channel is reactive, and reviewers look for it directly.
- **Opt out is immediate and brand wide.** Leave Conversation and the trigger words all stop sending at once, across automation, agents, campaigns, retries and anything scheduled. Not just the current thread.
    - Note: Apple requires MSPs to keep a table of closed conversations; continued sends after opt-out can be reported by the user via Report Junk, with Apple review and possible terms-of-service action. Also: a user who re-initiates returns with the SAME opaque user ID
- **The enrolment message carries the opt out** [Feedback]. The instruction belongs in the enrolment and confirmation template itself, not only in the moment of consent. Apple's own shape: a welcome, the brand name, a statement that the assistant is automated, and the opt out, closing on the pattern "Reply STOP anytime to turn off notifications."
- **A later conversation does not restore campaign consent.** A customer restarting a conversation restores your permission to reply inside that conversation. It does not restore permission to send notifications. Those are separate states and are reset separately.

2.10 Resolution, satisfaction and closing [CDS]

Satisfaction surveys. Present them on the channel, right after the interaction. Use descriptive labels instead of numbers, and a Quick Reply, or a Form Message for longer surveys.

When not to ask [Checklist]:

- Not after every FAQ answer
- Not before the task is resolved
- Not after a close, a Leave Conversation, or an opt out
- Never on a schedule that fires after the customer has closed the conversation

No SMS specific language. Phrases like "Messaging rates may apply" or "Data rates may apply" relate to SMS, not to this channel. Prohibited on screen, and equally prohibited in anything spoken about the channel.

Never say these [CDS, Checklist]:

- "This conversation has been closed"
- "Finish conversation"
- "Messaging rates may apply"
- "Data rates may apply"
- Anything implying the customer cannot come back

Instead, reassure the customer they can follow up at any time.

2.11 Policies: privacy, personal information and Terms of Use [CDS]

Personal information, only when necessary. Businesses must not request personally identifiable information until it is strictly necessary to resolve the customer's issue. Do not collect it speculatively or at the start of every conversation.

Privacy Policy and Terms of Use, Rich Link only. These must **never** be pasted as inline text in the conversation. Send them as a Rich Link to the brand's webpage. Send them on **two occasions only**: the customer's first engagement, **or when the policy has been updated**. Never at the start of every conversation.

2.12 Naming and terminology [MWYC]

Correct product naming is a pass criterion and incorrect naming is a named failure [ER]. This is a trademark requirement, not a style preference.

Use	Term	When to use
Yes	**Apple Messages for Business**	Full name. Headlines, first references and formal copy
Yes	**Apple Messages**	Acceptable short form in customer facing content and button labels
No	iMessage	Never. This refers to the personal messaging service, not the business channel
No	Messages for Business	Never. Always include "Apple" at the start
No	chat, text	Avoid using these terms to describe Apple Messages for Business buttons or flows
No	Apple logo in place of the word "Apple"	Never use the Apple logo to replace the word "Apple" in text

Use	Term	When to use
No	AMB	Never in public communications [Ops]
No	iMessage for Business, Apple Chat, Messages Business	Never [Ops]

Where an interface needs an unknown contact label, use "Apple Messages contact" rather than "Apple Business Contact", and do not call the channel "Apple Business" [Checklist].

Do not use wording that implies Apple endorses [BRAND] [Checklist].

The 30 July update widened naming from a conversation copy rule into a rule covering interface, onboarding, marketing and documentation surfaces as well. Scan localisation bundles and templates, not only the flow [Checklist].

Device and platform references [Ops]. Use iPhone, iPad and Mac. Do not reference specific iOS version numbers in marketing materials without checking with Apple business development for accuracy and currency.

2.13 Entry points [MWYC]

Every place a customer encounters your brand is a chance to start a conversation. The more visible your entry points, the more conversations you will have. Apple lists ten:

Message Suggest, Apple Maps, Website Button, App Button, Email and SMS, QR Code, NFC Tag, Social Media, Wallet Passes, Augmented Reality.

Enable native entry points easily. In Apple Business Register, check **"Show Message buttons for iOS and macOS"** to activate Place Card, Business Card and Message Suggest in one step. The phone number in your brand profile, or the location profile when there is only one location, is automatically activated in Message Suggest.

Message Suggest

The most powerful call deflection tool on the channel, and it only requires registering your phone numbers. When a customer taps any of your registered business phone numbers, on your website, in search results, or on Apple Maps, they see the option to message instead of call.

What it does for the business: reduces call volume by offering messaging as a faster alternative, improves customer satisfaction with asynchronous tap friendly support, and lowers support costs by shifting simple requests away from live phone queues.

How to set it up. Message Suggest is configured by Apple based on information you provide. Send an email to [**business-register@apple.com**](mailto:business-register@apple.com) with the Message Suggest form, including:

- All primary and high call volume phone numbers
- Your business phone contact hours
- Title and subtitle for the interface, up to 120 and 170 characters
- Translations if you need multi language support
- Intent and body parameters for each number
- Current call volume and number of agents

Best practices

- Register all high volume numbers, not just the main line
- Make sure registered numbers are tappable on your website, in E.164 format
- Set up an automated out of hours response
- Allow **five to seven days** for propagation before checking visibility

Because Message Suggest can start a conversation from a phone tap with no other context, the greeting has to work cold [Checklist].

Composing your entry point URL

Every entry point, whether a website button, QR code or email link, uses an Apple Messages for Business URL. Parameters let you capture intent, route messages and pre fill context.

```
https://bcrw.apple.com/urn:biz:<your-business-id>?biz-intent-id=order_support&biz-group-id=post_sales&body=Tap%20Send%20to%20start
```

Parameter	Name	What it does	Example
biz-intent-id	Intent ID	Identifies the purpose of the conversation, which entry point or use case triggered it. Lets you track performance by entry point and route appropriately.	order_support, appointment_booking, flight_disruption
biz-group-id	Group ID	Routes the conversation to the right team or department within your provider platform. Reduces triage steps when the destination is already known.	post_sales, reservations, billing_team
body	Pre filled message	Pre populates the customer's message field. All they need to do is tap Send. Reduces friction and increases conversion from entry point to conversation.	Tap%20Send%20to%20start

Use a different Intent ID for each entry point. This lets you measure which entry points drive the most conversations and understand where your customers are coming from.

Important. Parameters must not contain URI reserved characters: & # [ ] ( ) { } /

Entry point standards

- **Use a clear call to action.** Tell customers what to expect before they tap. "Style questions? We can help." or "Book an appointment via Apple Messages" performs better than a logo alone.
- **Keep entry points always on.** Do not disable buttons outside business hours. Customers should always be able to start a conversation. Automation handles the response when agents are not available.
- **Show buttons on supported devices only.** On websites, the Messages button hides automatically on unsupported devices. If you place buttons manually, use your content management system to detect Apple devices and show accordingly.
  - Apple Business Register has an 'Unsupported Devices' Redirect Page URL setting, where users entering from an unsupported device land instead of the default page
- **Pre fill the message body.** Adding a body parameter means customers only need to tap Send. A small change that meaningfully reduces friction at the start of the conversation.
- **Add an Intent ID to every entry point.** Even if you do not use routing immediately, Intent IDs let you understand where conversations come from and which entry points are most effective.
- **Place buttons where customers need help.** The most effective positions are contact pages, support pages, order confirmation pages and product pages, where customers are most likely to have a question.

2.14 Buttons and calls to action [MWYC]

Apple provides four approved call to action options plus an icon. Use one of them so customers understand what to expect before they tap. **Do not enable buttons until your account is approved to go live and Apple has reviewed the call-to-action (CTA) text.** Button assets provided by Apple must be used as supplied, without modification [Ops].

Button type	Best for
Message Us	General support pages and contact pages
Contact an Agent	When customers expect to reach a live person
Ask a Question	Product pages and pre purchase support
Get Help	Troubleshooting flows, order issues and support hubs
Messages for Business icon	Messages app icon only. Standalone icon in space constrained contexts such as widgets, or inline alongside other icons

2.15 Operational readiness [Ops]

Before enabling your account, confirm your team and systems are ready.

Staffing and coverage. Enough agents available to cover your advertised support hours. Define a clear escalation path for issues an automated agent cannot resolve.

Response time expectations. Set realistic and honest expectations **in your welcome message**. If live agent wait times vary, communicate this dynamically using automated messages.

Out of hours handling. Configure an automated out of hours response that informs customers when live agents are available. Do not leave customers without a response when they message outside business hours.

Testing before launch. Thoroughly test all entry points, automated flows, handoff to live agents and edge cases before going live. Use sandbox environments and real device testing on supported Apple devices.

Analytics and monitoring. Establish baseline metrics, response times, resolution rates and satisfaction scores, **before launch**. Set up dashboards to monitor performance and identify issues early. Capturing these after launch leaves you nothing to compare against.

Agent training. Train all live agents on the experience, including tone of voice, feature usage and escalation procedures. Agents should be familiar with asynchronous messaging expectations.

2.16 Marketing guidelines [Ops]

You may promote your Apple Messages for Business capability, but all activity must follow Apple's naming, branding and messaging guidelines.

Naming and terminology. Use the correct product name. See Section 2.12. Do not abbreviate "AMB" in public communications.

Apple branding. Do not use Apple logos, product images or trademarks in your marketing materials without prior written approval. Button assets provided by Apple must be used as supplied, without modification.

Feature availability. Marketing should only be executed when the feature is fully available to customers. Do not promote the capability before your account is live and approved.

Customer focused messaging. Focus on the value to the customer and the experience they can expect. Avoid technical jargon. Highlight convenience, speed and ease of use.

Approved description. Apple Messages for Business allows customers to connect with companies directly from the Messages app on iPhone, iPad and Mac. Customers can get support, make purchases and resolve issues, all in a familiar, trusted messaging experience.

What to avoid. "iMessage for Business", "Apple Chat", "AMB" in public materials. Claims about Apple's technology, roadmap or strategy. Apple metrics without prior approval.

2.17 The partner press announcement process [Ops]

Important. All public relations plans and press materials must be shared with Apple business development before any outreach. Do not contact media or publish materials before receiving Apple alignment.

This runs on its own clock. If you intend to announce, start it before the experience review completes.

When	What happens
6+ weeks before announce	Submit your completed plan template to your Apple business development contact. They share it with Apple public relations and the Apple product lead for review and feedback.
4 to 5 weeks before	Apple public relations and the product lead provide feedback. Business development communicates it back. Apple may share a press release template.
2 to 3 weeks before	Once Apple has aligned on your approach, share draft press materials with Apple business development. They review first, then the product lead, then public relations.
Final stage	Apple public relations routes final materials to Apple leadership for approval. Nothing is published or distributed before this step completes.

Guidelines for press activity

- **Time announcements to feature availability.** Messaging focuses on the value to customers and the customer experience, not on internal milestones or partnerships.
- **Share your plans at least six weeks in advance**, including your media list, before contacting any press outlet.
- **Share all press materials with Apple before distribution.** Blog posts, press images, videos and detailed pitches included. Press releases are approved case by case only. Joint releases with Apple are preferred over multiple separate releases.
- **Allow sufficient review time.** At least two to three weeks for press release reviews, at least two weeks for blog posts and pitches.
- **Align on any metrics or numbers before sharing publicly.** Customer satisfaction scores, volume figures and any other quantitative claim.
- **Spokespersons speak only on behalf of their own company.** Do not speak for Apple, make claims about Apple's roadmap or strategy, or represent Apple's position.
- **Forward Apple press inquiries appropriately.** Do not respond to press inquiries directed at Apple. Forward them to your Apple business development contact. Apple will forward to you any inquiries pertaining to your company.

Plan template sections

Section	What to include
Objectives	Goals of the activity, what you are trying to achieve, target audience, what success looks like
Approach and tactics	What you plan to do (blog post, media pitch, press release), where materials will be published, links to drafts
Press list	Outlets and reporter names, and when you plan to contact them. Shared at least six weeks before outreach begins
Timeline	When you will execute, key dates, internal deadlines, embargo dates or dependencies
Next steps	Open items, dependencies, actions required from Apple, questions for Apple business development or public relations

Send it to your Apple business development contact, who facilitates all communication with Apple public relations. **Do not contact Apple public relations directly.**

2.18 During - Design self check

This is the writer's quick pass, run at the desk while the flow is still being designed. It is not the test record. The formal, evidenced test record is **Document 3, the Experience Review Checklist and Test Cases**, which is what MA validates against at Step 3 and what accompanies the submission at Step 5. Every line here has a corresponding test case in Document 3.

Conversation

- ☐ Automated greeting arrives within 5 seconds and discloses that it is automated
- ☐ The opener names the assistant and says what it covers
- ☐ A one second typing indicator precedes every outbound payload, including back to back sends, and from live agents as well as the bot
- ☐ No typing indicator appears while nothing is being composed
- ☐ The opening pairs the greeting with a Quick Reply of up to five real top intents
- ☐ The Quick Reply menu leads with the most common options
- ☐ A clear written intent is answered rather than overridden by the menu
- ☐ A route to a person appears on every menu, and AGENT, HELP and MENU trigger the right behaviour
- ☐ Triage is never more than two levels deep
- ☐ No path in the conversation dead ends
- ☐ Unrecognised input gets a recovery message that re offers the options as a Quick Reply, then escalates
- ☐ Device locale drives language, and any switch is confirmed first
- ☐ The conversation never opens by asking the customer which language they want
- ☐ The conversation offers further help before the close, as a Quick Reply
- ☐ No information already given is asked for a second time

Features

- ☐ The experience uses platform features and is not a text only flow
- ☐ Introductory text precedes every rich element, including Authentication and Apple Pay
- ☐ Every card that carries an interactive element has its own image, and the Form splash screen has one
- ☐ Every interactive item carries a thumbnail on receivedMessage, replyMessage and each item option
- ☐ Bounded questions are answered by a Quick Reply rather than by typed text
- ☐ Any List Picker with five options or fewer has been converted to a Quick Reply
- ☐ At least one List Picker shows subtitles and secondary text, not titles alone
- ☐ Time Picker events that happen somewhere carry a location, and the time zone is explicit
- ☐ A location shared by the customer is acknowledged and reflected back before anything acts on it
- ☐ No brand card image has been forced onto Apple Pay or the Authentication card
- ☐ Every summaryText reads as a short label, not a sentence
- ☐ The confirmation image after a tap stays within the icon ceiling of about 150 pixels

- ☐ The Form review page sits at the end of the final section to be filled
- ☐ Sensitive form responses are marked private

Rich Links

- ☐ Every URL renders as a Rich Link with an image, detected automatically, including video
- ☐ No bare URL and no "tap to load" text link appears anywhere
- ☐ Every location renders as a Maps Rich Link
- ☐ Logo style link images are under 150 pixels wide

Data and policy

- ☐ Authentication is used before any order detail, account data or balance is shared
- ☐ Apple Pay is used for payment and no card details are requested in the thread
- ☐ No personal information is requested without the clarifying yes or no gate first
- ☐ No password or card number is ever requested as plain text
- ☐ Data collection questions use the QuickType phrasings
- ☐ Privacy Policy and Terms of Use are Rich Links, sent only on first engagement or after a policy update
- ☐ Opt in is an active choice and states how to opt out
- ☐ The enrolment and confirmation template carries its own opt out instruction
- ☐ Opt out keywords stop sending immediately, brand wide
- ☐ The business never messages first, except through an approved Business Invitation or there is relevant information related to the conversation and context the user was with the brand previously.

Live agent

- ☐ Business hours logic is configured, and an off hours message states when a live agent will respond
- ☐ Response time expectations are set in the welcome message
- ☐ When no agent is available, leaving a message in the conversation is the first option offered
- ☐ The response window is stated, and an agent replies to that message in the same thread
- ☐ The handover to a live agent is announced, and the agent introduces themselves on joining
- ☐ An estimated wait time is given whenever the response is not immediate
- ☐ Key details are collected before escalation
- ☐ An agent introduction script is defined and agents are trained

Naming, entry points and readiness

- ☐ Naming follows Section 2.12 across the flow, templates, interface labels and localisation bundles
- ☐ "chat", "text", "iMessage" and "AMB" appear nowhere customer facing
- ☐ Every entry point carries an Intent ID, and a Group ID where routing applies
- ☐ Entry point URLs contain no reserved characters
- ☐ The message body is pre filled where it helps
- ☐ Buttons use one of Apple's four approved calls to action and are not modified
- ☐ Buttons are not enabled until the account is approved to go live
- ☐ Entry points stay on outside business hours

- ☐ Registered phone numbers are tappable in E.164 format
- ☐ Staffing covers advertised hours and an escalation path is defined
- ☐ Baseline metrics are captured before launch
- ☐ The satisfaction survey uses descriptive labels, fires only after real resolution, and never after a close
- ☐ None of the prohibited phrases appear anywhere
- ☐ Every flow tested from the customer side on a real device

Section 3. What we have seen in reviews

Nothing here carries Apple authority. **(Field)** is a Messaging Advisory observation. **(Review)** is a pattern drawn from real Apple feedback on live integrations.

Three items previously in this section have moved to Section 2, because Apple v3.1 states them directly: dead ends, entry point placement, and the live agent handoff notification and wait time.

3.1 Our working translation of Apple's six principles (Field)

Apple's six are at Section 2.1. These are the seven statements we use in workshops, because they translate the principles into decisions a writer can act on. They are ours.

- **Be prompt.** The first automated reply arrives inside 5 seconds. Nothing in this channel justifies a customer waiting for an acknowledgement.
- **Be honest.** Automation says it is automation. A person is presented as a person. Neither pretends to be the other.
- **Be clear.** One question at a time, in the customer's words, not in the brand's internal vocabulary.
- **Be useful.** Every turn moves the task forward or hands it to someone who can.
- **Be respectful of the customer's control.** They decide when the conversation ends, whether they opt in, and what they share.
- **Be tappable.** Provide as many tappable options as possible rather than long text that requires a lot of typing. In a large proportion of cases the customer is on a mobile device and on the move.
- **Be asynchronous.** The customer can walk away and come back. Nothing in the copy pressures an immediate reply, and nothing implies the conversation has been terminated.

Design the close before you design the middle. (Field) Teams that start from the close write shorter flows.

3.2 Build and quality assurance habits

Treat the card image and the row thumbnails as two different checks. (Field) Teams that treat them as one thing ship the rows and forget the card, which is the pattern that fails most often. Two lines on your quality assurance list, not one.

Read every summaryText out loud before launch. (Field) The detail we see failed most often after the card image. If it sounds like a sentence, it is too long. A short label is right. Repeating the question back is not.

Count your bounded questions. (Field) Read the flow and count the questions ending in a question mark with only two sensible answers. Each one is a Quick Reply you have not built yet.

Audit against the feature inventory, not against your flow. (Field) Because "text only experiences that do not leverage platform features" is a named Apple failure, walk Section 2.5 top to bottom and write down why each feature is or is not used. An AI generated experience that answers everything correctly in prose still fails.

3.3 Openers and triage

An honest short menu beats a vague AI opener. (Field) Where an AI layer handles triage rather than a fixed menu, the AI must demonstrably do better than the menu would. If the automation can only really do three things, say so: "I can help with [A], [B] or [C] right now, or I can put you through to someone."

Name the scope in the customer's words, not the department's. (Field) "Here to help with orders, delivery and returns" lands better than "here to help with order lifecycle management".

Say how to opt out in plain conversational words too. (Review) Alongside the STOP pattern in the enrolment template, conversations should explicitly tell the customer how to stop, for example "Reply 'unsubscribe' at any time to opt out."

For a single language deployment, say so internally and revisit when a second market opens. (Field) The locale rule matters the moment it applies, and retrofitting it is more work than designing for it.

3.4 Rich elements and forms

Do not build a Form for one or two fields. (Review) For an intake with only one or two fields, such as a name and an email, a formal Form object is discouraged. A plain text conversational exchange is preferred: "What's your full name?" then "What's your work email address?" The Form is for structured intake of several fields.

Give the form a splash, a title, an introductory description and a review screen. (Review) The splash screen is treated as a best practice rather than an optional extra, so the customer knows what they are filling out before they start.

Put the form's "why" in a message bubble before the form. (Review) Not in the form's subtitle, where it gets cropped and missed.

Long text goes outside the feature bubble. (Review) The first line of a feature bubble should be the title. Long text gets cropped and becomes unreadable before the customer decides.

Model multi select and multi section properly. (Field) If the use case genuinely has them, build them rather than flattening everything into a single select.

3.5 Escalation and human handover

Keep an email escalation inside the channel. (Review) If an email is being drafted to support, the automation should help the customer compose it within the conversation rather than abruptly shifting them away from it. Apple expects the conversation keeps in the channel.

Update long waits every five minutes. (Field) If the wait exceeds what you promised, keep talking rather than going quiet.

3.6 Copy and tone

Use proper casing. (Review) Messages sent entirely in lowercase are often flagged as a poor customer experience, regardless of how informal the brand voice is elsewhere.

Short bubbles. (Field) Two or three lines. Long paragraphs read as email, not as messaging.

Match the customer's register. (Field) If they write in fragments, do not reply in full corporate prose. This does not override the casing point above.

3.7 Rich Links

A black preview fails. (Field) A video Rich Link with no background image is one of the fastest ways to draw a review finding.

"Tap to load" text links are not acceptable either. (Review) The rule is not only about bare URLs. Any text style link, including a "tap to load" prompt, fails. And the image inside a Rich Link must accurately reflect the content of the target page.

3.8 Shared location handling

Show it to your agent as a map, not a coordinate pair. (Field) An agent reading numbers will mistype them.

Treat it as personal data. (Field) Keep it for as long as the request needs it and no longer, do not copy it into systems that were not disclosed, and do not ask for it where a postcode or a store picker would answer the same question.

3.9 Metrics to watch after launch

Baseline these before launch, per Section 2.15. These are the readings we watch afterwards.

Metric	What good looks like
Time to first reply	Under 5 seconds, every time, not on average
Containment without frustration	Rising, while escalation requests stay flat
Recovery rate	Most unclassified turns resolved in one clarification
Escalation to resolution time	Inside the window you promised in the thread
Opt out rate after a notification	Flat. A spike means the notification was not what the customer consented to
Survey response rate	Falling response usually means you are asking too often, not that customers are unhappy
Conversations by Intent ID	Rising on the entry points you invested in. Flat on one you promoted means the button placement is wrong, not the channel

Provenance

- Apple, Conversation Design Standards v3.1, 21 July 2026
- Apple, Message with Your Customer v3.1, 21 July 2026
- Apple, Plan Your Customer's Journey v3.1, 21 July 2026
- Apple, Ops and Marketing Preparation v3.1, 21 July 2026
- Apple, Pass the Experience Review v3.1, 21 July 2026
- MSP Integration Checklist, Apple Feedback Update, 30 July 2026: items C.6, C.7, C.8, C.12, C.14, E.4, E.5, E.6, E.7, E.8, E.9, E.10, E.11, E.12, F.2, F.5, and the Section C note on introductory text before rich elements
- Direct Apple feedback on live integrations
- Messaging Advisory, Experience Review Process Overview v1.x: the feedback examples, distributed through Sections 2 and 3 and indexed at the front of this document
- Messaging Advisory field observations, marked (Field) in Section 3

Section 2 is drawn from Apple documentation or direct Apple feedback and every rule carries its source. Section 3 carries no Apple authority.